
Republican candidates are running for the hills

Published by

Heather Digby Parton

Estimated reading time

8 min

Added on

2026-09-28

Address

<https://www.salon.com/2026/09/27/republican-candidates-are-running-for-the-hills/>

Republican candidates are running for the hills

The big story coming out of the 2024 election was how [Donald Trump](#) orchestrated a realignment of American politics, bringing demographic groups that had long eschewed the Republican Party into the tent. Latinos, Black voters and young people, mostly males, had voted for him and the GOP in larger numbers than anyone could remember, and it was seen in some quarters as a sign that the party was embarking on a thousand-year reign. Conventional wisdom held that Trump was something of a magical figure who had defied the odds, defeated the majority of the legal and political efforts to hold him accountable, and triumphantly returned to power.

Many attributed the president's success to a new political power on the block — the so-called [manosphere](#), consisting of male podcasters with millions of followers who had enthusiastically endorsed Trump. Many pundits said that Kamala Harris lost the race because she didn't try hard enough to appeal to these influencers, even though many are heavily misogynistic and wouldn't have been open to her candidacy in any case. Their juvenile humor and oppositional defiance also happened, incidentally, to be perfectly matched to Trump's sophomoric style.

However, like transgressive boys everywhere, they have a short attention span; Trump has not turned out to be as fun as they thought he would be. Although anecdotal evidence suggests they have been less fervent followers of the president for several months now, The Wall Street Journal [analyzed](#) nearly 70,000 hours of podcasts to see if it was true. What they found was revealing: "Mentions of Trump's name per hour on conservative podcasts have fallen nearly 70% from their peak in the run-up to the 2024 election." Many are publicly unhappy with the economy and the war, both of which are seen as broken promises and could account for the decline in mentions, but the hosts are mostly spending their time trashing Democrats like James Talarico, the Texas state representative who is running for the Senate and [may just win](#). (Significantly, the king of the manosphere, podcaster Joe Rogan, is actually [a fan of Talarico](#).)

There are some other big names in the podcasting world, like Tucker Carlson and Megyn Kelly, who are now openly antagonistic toward Trump, mostly for opportunistic reasons. The pair are among the early crowd jostling for power within the post-Trump right-wing ecosystem. Kelly has [railed against the Trump family's alleged corruption](#), while Carlson appears to be positioning himself as a presidential candidate, with his iconoclastic takes on a number of issues and increasing talk of a third-party bid. He recently [told NPR](#) that Trump should be removed from office.

But mainstream conservative media is still largely on board the Trump train, although Fox News' firing of Maria Bartiromo for coordinating with the White House — hilarious as the network's outrage is, considering the cozy relationships between the president and Fox hosts Sean Hannity and Laura Ingraham — and its decision to stand against Trump in support of CNN, MS NOW and POLITICO has [revealed a schism](#). The Rupert Murdoch-owned Wall Street Journal has also been pulling no punches throughout the second term.

But what of the Republican establishment? Since Trump's exultant victory in 2024, they have behaved as if he were ordained by God to be America's reigning monarch, omnipotent and infallible. Republican governors have largely abdicated their own roles as one of the Constitution's checks and balances, agreeing to give up their own sovereignty to serve his agenda, while the GOP majorities in Congress have proven to be nothing more than trained seals happily signing on to the president's usurpation of their own power.

Until quite recently, there was no shaking the hold Trump had on the GOP base. They were willing to believe that everything wrong in the country was the fault of former president Joe Biden, and that Trump was left with a massive disaster he had to clean up. The truth, of course, was the opposite.

But you can't really blame them. Until quite recently, there was no shaking the hold Trump had on the GOP base. They were willing to believe that everything wrong in the country was the fault of former president Joe Biden, and that Trump was left with a massive disaster he had to clean up. The truth, of course, was the opposite. He actually inherited a recovering economy — [dubbed “the envy of the world” in 2024](#) by The Economist — and newfound global respect. If Trump had done nothing and simply continued the policies that were already in place — and then taken credit for them, as he is wont to do — he would be in a different position today. But he surrounded himself with radicals and sycophants, and he believed his own hype. The results have been a disaster.

As Republicans prepare to face the voters in the November midterms, they are finding out that the “magical” Trump mystique was actually luck and hot air. Reality still exists, and it bites. Hard.

As we head into the final month before the election, the polls appear very bad for Republicans. The House majority is almost certainly gone, and the Senate is increasingly in play, something that wasn't seriously contemplated six months ago. The president's approval ratings are in the low to mid-30s, and his ratings on the most important issues of the economy and the Iran war are even worse. Gasoline and diesel prices have turned the two big promises Trump made — to lower prices and keep the nation out of wars — into epic failures, and voters are livid.

Suddenly, GOP candidates are running for the hills. Candidates in tight races in battleground and red states — including [Mike Rogers](#), who is running for the Senate in Michigan against Democratic nominee Dr. Abdul El-Sayed in Michigan, and [Rep. Ashley Hinson](#), who faces Josh Turek, a Democrat, in Iowa — are [saying the Iran war must end](#). (As the New York Times pointed out, Hinson was among seven House Republicans who recently supported a resolution calling on the president to stop or seek congressional approval for military action in Iran.) Others are scrubbing or downplaying endorsements by or mentions of the presidents on their campaign websites. According to [The Washington Post](#), Mike Beltran, the Republican nominee running against Rep. Kathy Castor, D-Fla., touted on his website earlier this year how he had “stood with President Trump every step of the way.” That language has now vanished, along with photos of Trump and references to “America First.” At least seven other GOP congressional candidates, reported the Post, are doing the same. One Florida Republican. Rep. Maria Elvira Salazar, has even [publicly condemned](#) the president for elements of his radical deportation policy.

Want more sharp takes on politics? [Sign up for our free newsletter](#), *Standing Room Only*, written by Amanda Marcotte, now also a weekly show [on YouTube or wherever you get your podcasts](#).

Historically, this is common. Midterms are notoriously hard on the party in power, and presidents usually take the blame. Often, the approved strategy is for candidates to go ahead and distance themselves from the president, and try to win their races by portraying themselves as independent thinkers who will not rubber-stamp the unpopular majority's agenda. Whether it's [Bush in 2006](#) or [Obama in 2014](#), close midterm races almost always feature some version of that same sales pitch. The only exception in recent years I can think of is 1998, when the GOP's threats to impeach President Bill Clinton over the findings of the Starr Report with regard to his relationship with Monica Lewinsky [blew back on them](#), costing them seats and resulting in the resignation of the House

Speaker Newt Gingrich in disgrace.

But this time it is especially jarring considering the fealty Republicans have been required to show their leader — and have willingly given him — until now. That loyalty ended up not helping Texas Sen. John Cornyn, who lost his primary just a few months ago when Trump endorsed his opponent in retribution after Cornyn waited too long to endorse him in 2024. As the midterm campaign has unfolded, it's belatedly become clear to many Republicans that standing with Trump may be riskier, even among the party's base, than standing against him.

But they have a problem. The president won't shut up. To the chagrin of most of his own party, he is insisting on making the midterms all about him. A narcissist to the core, Trump believes that the only way Republicans win in November is if he is out there bragging and blaming and lying as he always does, because that has been the secret sauce that brings out MAGA voters. He has even released a [taxpayer-funded propaganda ad](#) — which is illegal — touting his alleged accomplishments.

No one should mistake the Republican retreat from Trump as a full-scale rebellion. Instead, it's a tepid, last-minute attempt on the part of some desperate candidates to show independence, knowing they may lose anyway — and that the president will say it's because they didn't support him enough anyway. The Republican Senate had a chance to take a stand on one of the biggest issues in the campaign, and the one that's causing the most pain for average voters: Iran. On Thursday [they voted down a resolution](#) to end the war. The tally was 50-49. When it comes to putting their votes where their mouths are, it's clear they will default to Trump as always. Voters, though, are finally seeing through them.

Read more

on the 2026 midterms

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.